

FOR SILPA SATHEESH, returning to India was never only about coming home. It was about living in a place where she wanted her child to grow up, embracing an education system that had shaped her own academic journey.

"I don't regret that decision," says Satheesh, an Assistant Professor at IIM Kozhikode. She wanted her child to grow up close to family in Kerala, surrounded by "love and mutual aid", on the banks of the Meenachil River. Professionally, she wanted to contribute to the public education system that had played a defining role in her own journey.

Satheesh holds a PhD in Sociology from University of South Florida. Much of her research draws on Kerala's socio-ecological landscape. For her, the decision was not about retreating from a global academic career but extending her research in a context she knows up and close. IIM Kozhikode gave an institutional setting supporting interdisciplinary learning and research. "There are, of course, socio-cultural rigidities and bureaucratic hiccups that pose unique challenges for faculty," she says.

Like Satheesh, a growing pool of Indian scholars trained overseas is looking to build academic careers in their home country. Most of them are young.

IIM Bangalore is one of the clearest examples. Among IIMs with more than 100 faculty members, it stands out for the size of its younger faculty—nearly 30% of its roughly 150 faculty members are below 35. A few years ago, the number was less than 10. The young faculty includes researchers who completed higher education outside the country and chose India over opportunities overseas. Sourav Mukherji, Dean, Faculty, Organisational Behaviour & Human Resources Management, IIM-B, says the shift reflects a broader evolution of the older IIMs. The traditionally teaching-intensive institutions have started focusing on research and publication as global rankings become closely linked to research output. "That has increased the importance of younger faculty," he says. "You cannot suddenly ask someone who has spent years in administrative responsibilities to start producing top-quality research papers. It is possible but would be exceptional." The shift has coincided with IIM-B's stronger global positioning. The school climbed seven places to the 21st spot in the 2026 FT 2025 Masters in Management rankings with gains in areas such as research and internationalisation.

The change is not just about recruiting younger faculty. Mukherji says research networks are becoming an increasingly important part of the equation. "Producing high-quality research is not just about being a good researcher. Whether a paper makes it into a leading journal can also depend on factors such as the data you have access to, the research collaborations you have developed, and the broader academic network you are a part of."

Internationally trained faculty can bring research networks, exposure to international practices and, in some cases, a strong publication record. But Mukherji says international credentials are not, by themselves, the selection criterion. "We are not explicitly giving a preference to people simply because they have studied abroad. The preference is towards younger faculty who are research-oriented and have the potential to contribute strongly to the institute's research agenda."

BRAIN CIRCULATION

The return of foreign-trained academics is a relatively recent trend. It would be premature to call it a reversal of the brain drain over the past many decades. Professor Anubha Agarwal, Economics Area and IIM-B Young Faculty Research Chair, says India's research environment has improved significantly even though it